Weird Autumn

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/30764738.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Categories:
F/M, M/M, F/F, Gen

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Entrapta/Hordak (She-Ra), Hordak & Baker (She-Ra), Horde Prime Clones (She-Ra)/Original Character(s), Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Catra & Hordak (She-Ra), Adora & Hordak (She-Ra)

Characters:
Entrapta (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Baker (She-Ra), Original Characters, Horde Prime Clones (She-Ra), SodaPop (She-Ra), Busgirl (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Post-Canon, Established Relationship, Dryl, Crypto Castle, Fluff and Angst, scratch that, Tooth-Rotting Fluff, Some Humor, Angry Hordak, Soft Hordak, Hordak being a bit of a longsuffering hordad, no spacebats were harmed in the making of this fic, Discussions about Homelessness, Adora the horsegirl, Embedded Images, alt text, Screen Reader Friendly

Language:
English

Collections:
Break the Cycle-verse

Stats:
Published: 2021-04-18 Completed: 2021-06-15 Words: 16,956 Chapters: 7/7

Weird Autumn

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/30764738.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Categories:
F/M, M/M, F/F, Gen

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Entrapta/Hordak (She-Ra), Hordak & Baker (She-Ra), Horde Prime Clones (She-Ra)/Original Character(s), Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Catra & Hordak (She-Ra), Adora & Hordak (She-Ra)

Characters:
Entrapta (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Baker (She-Ra), Original Characters, Horde Prime Clones (She-Ra), SodaPop (She-Ra), Busgirl (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Post-Canon, Established Relationship, Dryl, Crypto Castle, Fluff and Angst, scratch that, Tooth-Rotting Fluff, Some Humor, Angry Hordak, Soft Hordak, Hordak being a bit of a longsuffering hordad, no spacebats were harmed in the making of this fic, Discussions about Homelessness, Adora the horsegirl, Embedded Images, alt text, Screen Reader Friendly

Language:
English

Collections:

Break the Cycle-verse

Stats:

Published: 2021-04-18 Completed: 2021-06-15 Words: 16,956 Chapters: 7/7

Weird Autumn

by bishonenrockmysocks

Summary

Hordak's peaceful day running errands in the town village with Baker is disrupted by a pair of delinquents who've been relentlessly shadowing his every step. It's been 15 years since the fall of the Galactic Horde and Etherians everywhere have finally put Prime's atrocities behind them- so why can't these strange teenagers take a hint and do the same? Or, at the very least, stop insisting that he and Catra return to the old ways and *leave him be?*

"Bea Chase"

Chapter Notes

> Another unexpected one-shot prompted by these three asks on tumblr.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The bell above the entrance way tinkled as Hordak pulled the door open and held it for Baker to pass through. Cane clicking off of cobblestone and thudding dully against wood, he quickly stepped in behind her, glad to be out of the brisk autumn chill and in the sweet smelling warmth of the pastry shop. A familiar broad, round man of medium height stood up from behind the counter, his jovial smile partially hidden behind a reddish-orange mustache far thicker and bushier than the wispy strands of ginger and grey hairs clinging to his nearly bald head.

"Hello Maurice," Baker called. She stepped up to the counter, removing her knit cap and unraveling her scarf along the way. Hordak loosened his own scarf a bit as he followed her, giving Maurice a polite nod.

"Excellent, I was hoping one of you'd be by today!"

"Then you got it in?"

"Sure did! I've got both the amaranth flour and your usual order of caster sugar in the back. I can go grab it now, if you'd like?"

"That'd be great!"

"Give me just a minute then," Maurice said, turning on his heel and disappearing through a door behind the counter.

Baker looked up to Hordak. "Should we pick out a few goodies for the others before go?"

"I expected we would," he replied. "I believe Entrapta was rather enamored with the crocodile bun last time."

"I really should get Bri to teach me how to make those…" Baker mused as she started drifting towards the wall displays.

Hordak leaned a bit harder on his cane and bent over to inspect the colorful variety of baked treats within the counter's glass case. His lower back ached ever so slightly, but it was easy enough to ignore; even after all this time he still hadn't really gotten terribly used to the cold of the mountains and now, with the rainy season poised to begin in earnest, his joints had been protesting a bit more than usual.

"Busy likes the sugared roses and Soda the stuffed dates, right?" he called out.

"I'd say so," Baker chuckled and smirked at him over a rack of bread loaves. "They very nearly died of happiness the last time we brought them some."

"Goodness, well, we certainly can't have that, now can we?" His lips quirked upwards mischievously. "Or do you think they would be grateful to have such a blissful send off?" Satisfied by her amused snorting, he turned his attention back to the display case and eyed an array of tarts along the top row, mumbling to himself, "Hm, Imp *has* been very fond of rhubarb recently…"

Hordak looked up once more at the sound of footsteps as another clone brother stepped through the backroom door, carrying a tray of the very crocodile buns he'd been thinking of a few moments prior. The other clone paused, his honey colored eyes sweeping across the shop and landing on Baker who waved.

"Good to see you Bri!"

Brioche nodded to her and Hordak, a few strands of his light brown hair falling in front of his eyes and an almost imperceptible smile creeping up his face as he did so, before passing Hordak and heading to the shop's front display window.

To say Hordak was fond of this particular brother, an exceptionally shy individual who preferred to let his baking speak for him, would be an understatement. Not for the first time, he felt relieved that quite possibly the gentlest of his many brothers had found such a welcoming home and fulfilling relationship with Maurice; as far as he was concerned, there were few in all of Etheria who deserved happiness as much as the two of them did and seeing them together never failed to warm his heart.

Heavy footfalls heralded Maurice's return, a small wooden crate in hand.

"Sorry about the wait," he grunted, sighing in relief as he set the crate down on a solid portion of the counter near the register. "Had to move a couple things around to get to it."

"No bother!" Baker said.

Maurice pushed the crate closer to her as she stepped up, letting her inspect the flour and sugar bags inside. He looked across the room to Brioche and then at Hordak, raising his eyebrows in the direction of the window.

"You two bring a couple of tag alongs this time?"

Hordak sighed and looked, already knowing what he'd see.

Yes, sure as thunder in Dryl, there was his latest set of misguided idiots, standing by the plaza fountain outside and clearly visible through the window, trying not to look like they were watching Brioche arrange his display.

Baker giggled.

"Hordak's reached celebrity status with the kids recently."

He wrinkled his nose. "If *that* is how you would label this ill-conceived foolishness, then yes."

"Oh?" Maurice chuckled. "And what new trouble are they getting up to now?"

"*Apparently,* stories of my time in the Fright Zone are going around again and some of the more rebellious teenagers have taken to idolizing my imbecilic actions."

"Really? The whole-" Maurice wiggled his fingers in the air, "-dark shadow lord thing?"

"Indeed." Hordak rubbed at his temple.

"And let me guess- those two outside want you to pull out a laser cannon or show them how to drive a tank?"

"*Precisely*," Hordak ground out. "With any luck, they will figure out I have no world domination plans soon and *leave*."

Maurice let out a booming laugh. "Not much for an adoring public, are you?"

"At least my... *admirers*," Hordak growled. "have been generally quiet and well behaved."

Baker snorted and Maurice gave him a questioning look.

"You should see some of the strays showing up at Catra's front door," he continued, rolling his eyes. "They come expecting a wild woman ready to abandon responsibility and torch a town and instead discover a mother up to her eyes in housework and focused on caring for a rambunctious troublemaker of her own."

"Usually they give up after a few days," Baker explained, patting Hordak's arm. "But those two outside have been following him around like a pair of lost puppy dogs for nearly a full two weeks."

"Ah, I can see how that might grow a bit old," Maurice nodded.

"Thankfully," Baker continued. "All these kids like to talk a big game but it's all a bunch of bluster and they mostly just end up

leaving messes and stealing a few trinkets here or there."

Maurice shook his head and set his hands on his hips, a wistful smile peeking out from under his mustache. "It's good to know kids never really change, no matter how much time goes on."

"That's what I thought too."

"Better they get it out of their system while they're still young and have all the time in the world to come to terms with it," said Maurice. "Heck, compared to when we were kids, I'm *glad* this is the kind of trouble they're getting up to. A little drinking and partying, getting into harmless scraps- that's how it *should* be." He swept a hand towards Baker. "Not like how things went for us- you remember, right? Supply shortages, protests and arguing, choosing between an education and supporting the family, getting pulled into someone's army or- worse- *volunteering* because you're too stupid to know better about all that pushy, claptrap advertising."

Baker nodded back knowingly while Hordak shifted uncomfortably beside her.

Noticing, Baker elbowed him lightly. "Relax, it's *fine*."

"If you insist," he mumbled.

"I do." Her stern look brightened a moment later. "Oh right! Goodness, Maurice, you should *hear* the things they like to call themselves- it's *adorable.* Hordak, what was it these two said their names were?"

"Lord…" He pinched the bridge of his nose and closed his eyes, letting out a pained groan. "*Lord Shadow Runner* and, eugh, *Mistress Blood Slicer.*"

Maurice fell into a fit of raucous laughter and even Brioche, empty tray tucked against his side, was smiling warmly when he came to join them at the counter.

“I think I get it now,” the patissier wheezed out, dabbing at the corners of his eyes with the edge of his apron.

“And can you blame them?” Baker grinned, pointing a thumb over her shoulder at Hordak. “The mystique of a pair of brooding, misunderstood anti-heroes? Just the two of them against the *whole* world-”

“Absolutely irresistible to an angry teenager!”

“I will have to take your word for it,” Hordak scowled at the pair of giggling humans, face heating up. Brioche’s empathetic look and accompanying shoulder shrug eased his embarrassment somewhat; clearly he did not understand what their companions found so funny either.

“Well,” Maurice said, hand to his chest as he took in deep breaths. “If it’s any consolation, I’d say them misunderstanding what the Etherian Horde was like is a good sign that things have properly calmed down by now.”

“I suppose,” Hordak sighed. “Although it does not make it any less irritating.”

“True,” Baker snorted.

“Several people,” Hordak continued. “including Entrapta, have counseled me to be understanding and to indulge in these absurd fantasies of theirs where possible, but this entire ordeal is *really* beginning to wear thin on my patience.” He shook his head. “It would be nice to be able to run errands in town again without-”

There was a sudden and loud crashing of breaking glass behind him and Hordak flinched back just in time to see a brick clatter across the floor and bounce away under a shelf as Baker shrieked in surprise next to him and Maurice startled out a loud curse. On his other side, between him and Maurice, Brioche stood stock still, clutching his tray against his chest hard enough to leave scratches in the metal. Maurice and Baker were both breathing heavily from fright but Brioche was barely breathing at all, his eyes wide, body

tense as a bow string, and the whites of his ears showing from how low they lay.

Hordak recognized that posturing. *Intimately*. Brioche was somewhere else entirely at the moment and, whatever he was seeing, it wasn't the bakery.

"Bri?"

Good, Maurice had caught on quickly.

The worried man cautiously reached out a large hand to delicately touch Brioche's shoulder and, when he didn't flinch away, moved closer to rub the clone's back. Gradually, Brioche's breathing picked up and his muscles relaxed enough to begin trembling instead.

The pounding of Hordak's heart transformed from startled adrenaline to a furious hammering that seemed to drown the entire world away as he looked from the couple, to the mess of glass and ruined food, to Baker; he was grimly pleased to see that she shared his dark look.

"I'll stay here and help clean up if you'll-" she began.

"Yes," he replied softly and then caught Maurice's eye. "Please leave this matter to me."

Maurice nodded and began guiding Brioche into the back of the store, whispering softly to him.

"I will return shortly," he announced before turning on his heel and striding out the door.

He was unsuprised to find a crowd gathering outside the shop; it *was* midday in the busiest part of town. He looked around at them all, scanning the gathering for his woebegotten misfits.

"Which way did they go?"

He barely got the question out before several hands pointed to his left.

“Thank you,” he replied tersely. Turning, he paused mid step and looked back to the crowd. “And if someone would be so kind as to also fetch the glazier…?”

“On it!” a member of the crowd shouted before sprinting down the street. That seemed to break the spell on the gathering and several more people began breaking away to fetch brooms and dust pans.

Satisfied, Hordak stalked up the street after his prey, eyes narrowed and occasionally hissing through his teeth. Clearly these *children* had not placed much effort in covering their tracks because several startled and annoyed villagers, upon catching sight of him coming in their direction, were able to quickly put two and two together and point him along without him ever needing to ask the question.

By whatever power still existed in this universe, bless the Drylians for having more common sense than the average Etherian.

Chapter End Notes

> Brioche's crocodile buns are a reference to this post about Sri Lankan kimbula banis.
>
> Also, "Soda" and "Busy" are shortenings/slight renamings of the other two Drylian staff members, because while "Baker" makes for a fine name, "SodaPop" and "Busgirl" are decidedly *not* and I feel like they deserve better.

"Die Anywhere Else"

Chapter Notes

> The kobold girl is inspired by lost-in-derry's concept art. I might not be using the lore piece they provided (or their other *amazing* lore ideas), but I loved how they completed the show's design so much, I knew I had to use it somewhere. It might seem like not that big a deal, but lost-in-derry flipped a switch in my head with their art that made it so "that weird sewer gremlin species" was an actual valid and usable concept for me and I can't thank them enough for posting and sharing it with us all.

His quarry was not silent either. As he drew closer, he quickly discovered he didn't need anyone to point him towards where they'd hidden- he could hear them bickering and squabbling several buildings away and smell the acrid stink of freshly lit tobacco.

He peeked around the edge of one building and, yes, there- down an alley- stood the grey furred canid boy and the yellow-green skinned kobold girl. Both wore an eclectic assortment of patched and baggy denim and plaid; the boy, especially, sported a cracked leather coat while the girl had adorned herself in a wholly unnecessary number of chains and spiked accessories.

From his prior observations and shared musings with Entrapta, he'd managed to deduce the canid likely hailed from out by the Wastelands, if his ratty canvas military style backpack and sand-crusted boots were anything to go by. Likewise, after a bit of quiet querying around the kobold families living in the castle village, they were reasonably certain the girl was probably Drylian in origin but from one of the neighboring towns.

They'd yet to locate any missing persons reports or other indicators that people were looking for them though, so they couldn't be entirely sure the pair were runaways or if trying to

return them to their homes was even the safest action in this instance. Delicacy and a gentle approach had proven to be the most effective method with the wide variety of other youths who'd taken to following him in the past year, so he and the rest of the castle residents had agreed to try to subtly keep an eye on the wayward drifters and help them in whatever little ways presented themselves in the moment. Upsetting though it all was, he'd sworn to himself he would keep his temper in check until they could figure out a more satisfying solution.

Well, no more. A line had been crossed and he wasn't having it.

Taking his cane up by its middle, Hordak silently made his way down the narrow passage between a mechanic's garage and a cobbler's shop. He drew up behind his targets and *loomed*, waiting to see how long it would take the fools to notice they'd been caught.

He was not disappointed- their powers of observation were pathetically nonexistent- and their screams of fright were like a sweet symphony to his enraged heart.

They tried to run, of course, but barely managed to stumble to the edge of his reach before he snatched them both by their upper arms and yanked them back. Eyes narrowed to sharp slits, he growled harshly at their struggles and they went limp immediately, staring back up at him with mixed expressions of shock and genuine fear.

Hm.

Good to know he could still do that, even if a pair of children with no sense of self-preservation made for a poor test of skill.

Confident that they would not immediately bolt away, he let his grip slacken to a more reasonable hold (angry though he was, there was no sense in harming them) and he half dragged the pair out of the alleyway and began the not-so-inconsiderable walk back up the hill leading to Crypto Castle.

By the time they'd reached the front gates the mild ache in his lower back had upgraded to a sharp twinge; an inevitable conclusion given how tense he was and that his cane currently shared hand space with the kobold girl's perhaps too-thin arm. He would pay for his recklessness and lack of self-control later, but he really could not bring himself to care in the moment.

Pulling the duo inside, he wordlessly passed a surprised Soda and veered them through an open archway into a sitting room just off the foyer entrance. He finally let them go and pointed at a couch, hissing a low *"sit"* which they, thankfully, complied with.

"Why would you do something like that?" he growled.

When neither of them spoke up he cracked the foot of his cane against the floor hard enough for the force to jolt back up his arm and the teenagers to jump and squeak in alarm.

"Answer me!"

The kobold girl gaped up at him in mute terror while the canid boy squinted down at his lap, ears flat against his head.

"It was just some fun," the boy grumbled.

"*This* is what you consider *fun?"*

The canid flinched. "We just thought…"

"Thought *what*, exactly?" He hissed viciously back to the boy. "That something like this would *impress* me? Maurice and Brioche are two of the absolute kindest people in this entire community! What would make you think I would *ever* approve of you harming them!?"

"The Horde used to-"

"The Horde!? The Horde had *rules!"* Hordak roared. "Organization! Accountability! I do not know what absurd stories have been

stuffed into those heads of yours but senseless acts of wanton destruction like this were met with discipline and punishment!”

The kobold girl head bowed and she started wringing her hands nervously but the canid’s ears, still low, came forward as he frowned up at Hordak defiantly.

“*You* used to destroy stuff all the time!”

Hordak snarled. “I have *never*-”

“Yeah you did!” the boy shot back, pointing up at him. “Like the time you and Commander Catra mowed down half the Fright Zone or the time you guys showed that stuck up sea-witch in Salineas who’s boss!”

Hordak took a sharp intake of breath and reared back a step. It took a conscious effort to keep his ears still- the boy would know how to read such an obvious tell and he could not afford weakness in front of him if he wished to retain control- and a tapping sound behind him made for a welcome cover.

Entrapta was there, leaning against the doorjamb with her arms crossed, the reinforced toe of one of her boots tapping lightly at the floor behind her. She was silently considering the teenagers in front of him with a neutral expression and, when she looked to him but still said nothing, he took a deep breath and turned back to the problem at hand.

“And do you know *why* I did those things?” he said tightly.

The boy smirked. “Because blowing shit up is rad?”

“No,” he growled. “I did those things because I was *sick*.”

The boy scoffed but the kobold girl looked up at him, eyes wide.

“I *used* the war,” he continued. “to hide the fact that I was hurting and afraid and- and so unbearably lonely and *miserable* and I did that because I didn’t know how to deal with *any* of it.”

"*You* were a-afraid?" rasped the girl.

"Yes, and before you two start getting any ideas, *so was Catra*."

"B-but everyone says you guys were brave…" she croaked.

"Brave?" Hordak barked out a harsh laugh. "There was nothing *brave* about us! We were *terrified,* all the time, and had no idea what to do with all that fear, so we turned it into anger and destroyed things because it made us feel a little less helpless and pretend like we had some sort of control over our lives when we *didn't."*

"Yeah, yeah, we get it," the boy groaned, head lolling back. "Uhg, man, all you clones really *are* the same; cult this, Prime that. We know, we *kno-"*

Before his thinking brain could catch up with the unexpected hurt searing him to his core, Hordak stepped forward and leaned into the boy's face, baring his teeth in a loud snarl.

"You don't know a damn thing about it!"

The kobold girl shrank back, crawling as far away from them as the couch would allow, and the boy's eyes narrowed as he growled back. Before either of them could say another word, however, familiar strands of purple hair came between them, pushing the boy back into the cushions and lightly tugging at Hordak's arm and chest.

He let Entrapta draw him back, dreading her expression and cursing himself for letting a petulant child goad him into losing control. When he looked at her, however, there was no disappointment or chastisement, only bleak understanding and a hand rubbing his bicep out of view of their audience.

Hordak closed his eyes and breathed deeply for several moments and, when he opened them again and Entrapta nodded a fraction in approval, he turned back to the kids. The canid was sneering

but the kobold was still glancing between him and the boy cautiously.

"I do not know why you two are so obsessed with me," he began, slow and measured. "But you need to stop and figure out what it is you *really* want because, I *assure* you, it's not to be like me. Whatever problems you're running away from, take it from me- going around and making other people's lives harder *isn't* going to help and will only make things harder for you later. Do yourself a favor and quit while you're ahead."

Entrapta had hardly needed Busy to come find her; she'd heard Hordak shouting nearly halfway across the castle. How long had it been since she'd last heard his voice raised like that? Years, it must have been.

She'd already been on her way to investigate when the frazzled woman had run into her and Soda looked just as distressed when they reached the foyer. She quietly reassured them both and stepped into the entrance of the sitting room.

Entrapta couldn't say she was terribly surprised when she caught sight of the kids sitting in front of Hordak; they'd been pushing their luck with him already and, with the way her partner was positively *seething* , it appeared their fortune had finally run out.

No wonder why on that account either, the way the canid was mouthing off. When Hordak pulled back from the mention of Salineas as though he'd been burned, she made a point of loudly tapping her boot, hoping that- yes, good, she'd caught Hordak's attention. It had the calming effect on him she'd hoped for and he turned away from her when it became clear she wasn't going to interfere; this was his fight, not hers, and she wasn't going to get in the way of that unless he needed her to.

She fished her data pad out and, eyes flicking periodically between the screen and the group, she typed out a quick message to Baker. She was already starting to piece together an

idea of what had happened and when Baker sent back a couple of hastily taken photos, that more than filled out the remaining details.

While doing her best to keep track of Hordak's surprisingly honest description of his time in the Fright Zone, she sent a few more messages to Baker, asking her to let Maurice and Brioche know she'd happily foot the bill for a new display and- no- she would *not* be debating the matter with them; she would pay for the window and any other upgrades the glazier suggested, end of story.

As she watched, Entrapta could not help but feel a pang of sympathy for the kobold girl; she had the same air about her as a few of the other kids who'd meandered in- new to wandering, struggling with how much harder life was as a drifter than most people expected, and only now realizing maybe they'd gotten themselves completely in over their head alongside someone who was maybe less reliable that they'd thought.

The boy, on the other hand, had the defiant attitude of someone who'd been at it for a long while and, by this point, only knew how to dig themself a deeper hole; an impression which he evidenced rather clearly by bringing up Prime.

Oh, son of a bitch.

Resisting the urge to groan, she quickly moved to put herself between the two hot heads. She had full faith that Hordak would not harm the boy, at least not in any lasting way, but her partner had now visibly reached his breaking point and this needed to end *now* before it got any worse. Besides, while she might believe in Hordak's sense of personal restraint, she held no such conviction towards the canid now pawing roughly at the hair she'd shoved him back with.

Once she was reasonably certain tempers had cooled off, she withdrew her hair from them both and waited for Hordak to say his piece and leave. She continued waiting after his retreat,

watching the room's archway until Soda looked to her and nodded.

A thick silence descended on them all and Entrapta propped her elbow against a shelf of hair, rubbing her chin while she considered the pair. To her credit, the kobold tried several times to start conversation, looking between her and the canid in increasing degrees of apprehension before giving up and dejectedly picking at the jewelry around her wrists.

Entrapta sighed and removed the welding mask from her head to run a hand through her hair.

"Look, I get it."

The canid snorted derisively and rolled his eyes.

"I do though. I totally see how you guys heard all these stories about the 'big bad Horde Lord' Hordak and could think he was cool." She huffed in amusement. "I mean, I *married* the guy, so *clearly* I agree. And also, yes, blowing stuff up is a lot of fun and all that too."

"He's not cool. He's a lying, washed up loser reject who-"

"Who was one of the four people responsible for killing the most dangerous existential threat the universe has ever known," she replied tartly. " *Watch it*- I was the second and you're bullshit isn't fazing anyone."

The boy's patchy fur seemed to pale slightly and he dipped his head.

"As I was saying," she continued. "What you guys have been hearing are *stories* and, even if some of them are true, Hordak's *different* now. He isn't proud of who he was back then and, besides, all the stuff he's accomplished since is *loads* cooler anyway."

She looked down at her mask, fingering its edges.

"I know the world can be a cruel place and there are a lot of people out there who delight in hurting others for the sake of it. I wish that wasn't true, but it is and I'm the last person who's going to deny it."

She returned her mask to its place, hair curling back into the beehive bun she'd been favoring recently. The kobold watched in poorly concealed fascination and Entrapta couldn't help but smile at her.

"And I'm sorry Hordak wasn't the person you were expecting, but he's right. Whatever it is that's bothering you guys, you need to figure it out. You don't even have to do it alone- there are a lot of good people here who'd be happy to help if you just *ask them* instead of throwing bricks through their windows and scaring them so badly you force one of them to relive a brutally painful part of their past."

"Wait- wha..?" the kobold girl breathed.

"If you guys need a place to stay," Entrapta continued. "We can make that happen, no problem. If you need someone to talk to or a job, one you actually *like* that can put all that restless energy to good use, we can make that happen too. But I'm telling you both right now, following Hordak around and causing him trouble isn't helpful *or* wanted."

Her voice hardened a fraction and she directed a stern gaze towards the canid.

"Not to mention taunting him with reminders of the worst part of his life."

The boy squirmed in his seat, trying and failing to hold his ground against her.

"Tch." His head turned away and he gnashed his teeth. "Whatever. Can we go now?"

"Yes," she said, stepping to the side. "You may."

The canid practically bolted out the room and she could see Soda and Busy shaking their heads at him as they craned to watch his retreat.

The kobold girl, on the other hand, was far more hesitant. She stood almost as quickly but remained rooted to the floor, rocking a little in place and twisting her fingers in the plastic skull necklaces hanging down her chest.

"Y-your m-majesty...I...mm…"

Entrapta smiled at her encouragingly but it soon became clear the girl wasn't going to be able to get anything more out for now.

Damn it all, but she could feel her heart melting at the sight; she had such a soft spot for underdogs and outcasts. How many times had she herself been in this girl's shoes, where uttering a single word felt like climbing a mountain? And how many times had Hordak given her this exact same confused look of fear, pleading, and remorse?

"It's okay," she said softly. "You don't have to decide right now, or ever, even. Everyone's welcome in Crypto Castle, so please consider what I said a standing, open offer."

The girl's eyes widened and her mouth hung open for a long moment before she bobbed her head in what Entrapta was pretty sure was supposed to be an awkward attempt at a bow and scurried away.

Hands on her hips, Entrapta shook her head in amusement and sighed.

Well, that was one fire put out.

She checked her data pad to see how things were progressing at Maurice's and was relieved when Baker sent back reassurance that things were just about cleaned up and going smoothly; no permanent harm done.

Good. Now she just needed to find her partner and, lucky for her, Hordak was precisely where she'd guessed he'd be.

Stepping into their lab, she spotted him sitting in the carpeted lounge area off the side of their workspace. His back was to her and, as she came closer, she found him slouched forward with his face in one hand and the other hanging loosely off his knee. Imp sat beside him on the couch, patting his brother's arm, and when he spotted Entrapta he gave her a bewildered look.

He started signing *"What the hell-"* to her, but she cut him off, signing back *"It's complicated, give me a minute"* and smiled gratefully at the little clone's understanding nod.

She stepped in front of Hordak and, when he did not move, reached out to gently start unwinding the scarf around his neck. Setting it aside and tossing her work gloves onto the couch with it, she ghosted her fingers over the velvety soft skin around the back of his skull. He shivered and tilted further forward, gently resting his forehead against her chest as she rhythmically dragged her blunt nails back and forth along the edge of his hairline.

"So many years," he whispered. "and *still* the consequences of my mistakes keep coming back to me."

"This isn't your fault," she replied softly, brushing a kiss against his hair.

"You say that and yet every time I think we've finally moved on, that I've paid it all back and gotten free of it at last, I get pulled back by the rip current and I'm drowning all over again."

His voice cracked and she pulled him closer, hair unraveling so it could wrap around him in a more complete embrace.

"Oh, Hordak…"

"Home Again"

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"There, good as new. All that's left is to let the sealant cure and settle overnight. One of us'll be by tomorrow to do the paint work. Still the same design, yeah?"

"Yeah." Maurice said to the woman beside him. "And, thanks again for the rush job Bea. Bri and I really do appreciate it, especially since you stayed so late to make sure it got done."

"No problem." Beatrice waved a hand and hefted the last of her tools into her truck bed. "Besides, after all that work you guys put into helping me make Mae's homecoming special last month, it's the least I could do."

"Well, alright. Goodnight Bea."

"'Night Maurice."

He watched the reptilian clamber into her truck and drive off before turning to go back inside the shop. As he set about the usual routine of closing up for the night, he took a long moment to pause and admire the shiny new window. There was still about another day's worth of work to be done to get the shop back to normal, but he had to admit, things were already looking pretty good.

Flicking off the last of the lights, he moved into the backroom for the final checks there as well. While he'd hoped Brioche had moved to their living space upstairs while he'd been outside with the glazier, he was unsurprised to find him still in the kitchen, sitting on his usual stool at the prep table and sculpting a batch of pastry flowers for them to throw into the oven in the morning. He looked tired and still a little tense, but otherwise greatly improved over earlier, a small detail which Maurice couldn't help but feel

glad of; the other man seemed to be rebounding from these kinds of scares far better than he used to.

Bri didn't look up and his hands never stopped moving, but the ear that twisted in his direction was a clear indication his entrance had been noticed. Normally, they'd be done with work by now and relaxing for the evening, but if Bri wanted to stay up late and do a bit of comfort work like old times, that was fine by him. Granny had always said the best cure for a bit of upset was getting your hands dirty with a bit of dough and even after all these years, she'd never been wrong.

Spotting the untouched fruit and sugar sitting on the table, Maurice stepped over to the sink to wash his hands before sitting down on the opposite side of the table. He reached out and pulled the ingredients and necessary tools closer to himself and got to work chopping and prepping the fruit filling for his partner. Although the clone never said a word, Maurice smiled when Bri's foot gently bumped and curled around his.

They sat and worked together in companionable silence for some time, enjoying the comforting motions and familiar sounds after the chaos of the day. Lulled into what Granny called "the baker's trance," Maurice almost didn't catch Brioche's words when he finally spoke up.

"Mory?"

"Hm?"

"Why do young people intentionally cause mischief?"

"Pardon?"

"It's not something my brothers and I are familiar with but you and Baker seemed to treat it as common, if not normal."

"Ah. Hmm." He wrinkled his mustache and set aside his muddler. Dipping a tester spoon into the mix to check the sweetness, he added another tablespoon of sugar and passed the bowl to his

partner. He hummed again as he sat back on his stool, arms crossing thoughtfully and hand stroking the stubble on his chin.

“How do I put this?” he mumbled. “Funny, I thought this would be easier to explain but now that I’m thinking on it, it’s a sticky mess.”

The corner of Brioche’s mouth quirked up as he began ladling fruit into the centers of his flowers.

“Thing is,” Maurice finally said. “Rebellion’s a pretty normal thing for kids. It’s a natural part of the growing process- they’re testing their abilities and stretching their limits- and some kids rebel more than others. For the most part it’s just that they can feel themselves getting close to the independence of adulthood and, even though they’re still not completely ready for it, they’re antsy and itchy to try what they’ve learned and get some first hand experience. They start having opinions their parents don’t and start questioning the world around them and all that restlessness mixes with their hormones and it’s the perfect storm of young people who don’t know better yet doing stuff they probably shouldn’t because they’re angry or sad or trying to impress someone." He rubbed at the back of his neck. "There's not a whole lot of sense to it, to be honest, but it's just kind of something that happens and the best thing us adults can do is try to minimize the danger for them and be there to help’em clean up when they’ve made their mistakes.”

Brioche nodded.

“What’s *not* normal,” Maurice continued. “is for kids to be running away from home or getting involved in the dangerous kind of trouble like those two from earlier. Kids break stuff all the time- sometimes by accident, sometimes because they’re angry and don’t know how to control it- but usually the stuff they break is small or unimportant. What those two did to us isn’t the normal kind of harmless mischief.”

“How do such things benefit them?” Brioche asked, brow crinkling.

“It doesn’t, really. Sure, there’s the short term rush of doing something forbidden or getting a little petty revenge against someone or something that’s hurt you, but it doesn’t actually solve anything.”

“Then why?”

“Well, sometimes it’s the only way these guys can get out all that pent up anger and pain. The ones who run away from home or who choose to live outside the system as drifters usually don’t do it because it makes them happy or because they want to- they do it because not having a place to sleep or a reliable source of food is still somehow better than the places they left. Sometimes it’s stuff that’s kind of like what you and your kin are familiar with- abusive family or dangerous situations, while other times it’s because they got caught up in something they can’t get out of or something’s happened to them and they don’t see any other way out.”

Brioche hummed, swapped his tray of completed pastries out for a new one, and continued spooning mashed fruit into the dough.

“And it can be real frustrating because you want to help them, but some of them don’t want the help, or aren’t ready for it, or they do want it but have no idea how to ask for it or trust someone enough to accept it. On top of that, a lot of them dig themselves into such deep holes, they feel like it’s impossible to believe in others to help them get out of it, let alone face the guilt and shame that comes afterwards.”

"I believe I can understand that," Brioche whispered.

"Yeah." Maurice sighed. “The biggest thing most folks forget is that these people aren’t bad. They’re hurting and struggling and there’s rarely an easy answer to their problems which makes it difficult to deal with since most people don’t have what it takes to tackle those kinds of issues. They deserve our compassion and sympathy, even when they do cruel and pointless things like smash your window or scare the daylights out of you.”

He stifled a yawn and rubbed his face.

“Although,” he continued. “Even though I said all that, it’s okay to be mad at them sometimes too.”

Brioche finally stopped his work, setting the spoon down inside the fruit bowl. He rested his hands loosely on the table and continued looking down at the incomplete tray of flowers in front of him.

“I do not think anger is what I feel.”

“Oh?” Maurice quirked an eyebrow. “Then what are ye feelin'?”

“...disappointment.”

As he watched Entrapta mull over the pieces spread across the complex game board, eyebrows drawn down tightly and tongue sticking out one corner of her mouth, Hordak strained to suppress a laugh. To his right, Imp was sprawled lazily on his pillow, flipping through his data pad and apparently a great deal less amused by Entrapta’s expressions than he was.

“I’m afraid," he finally said. "you are going to need to make a move at *some* point today.”

“Yeah, yeah, I know, don’t rush me.” Entrapta made a face at him and blew out an exasperated puff of air. She sighed and shuffled around a few cards before finally declaring her actions and moving her miniature plastic spaceship in a circuitous route across the board, pausing occasionally to roll dice or pick up little blue chits. “There.” She waved a hand at Imp. “Your turn.”

“[Uhg, *finally*]” the miniature clone parroted in Soda’s voice, rolling his eyes as he sat up.

She slumped back into the couch cushions, a strand of hair unraveling from her bun and reaching out for a macaron from the tray beside her. Her mouth dropped open, confection hovering in

the air beside her, as she watched Imp quickly play his own cards and maneuver his ship across the board. He passed play to Hordak and she began making increasingly scandalized sounds as he too made short work of his turn and attended to the game's new round upkeep instructions.

Task completed, Hordak settled back into his armchair and looked at her innocently. "It appears to be your turn again."

"What?" she half shrieked. The forgotten macaron was returned to its tray as she shook her hands at the coffee table between them. "H-how!?"

He shrugged and nonchalantly picked at a piece of lint clinging to the sleeve of his sweater. "Simple: Imp and I each took our turns. Now play passes back to you."

"No, I know that, *smartass*, I mean how did the two of you *possibly* manage to complete *both* your turns in- what? Two minutes? Three?"

Imp tittered next to them.

Entrapta shot him a dirty look before pinning Hordak with a suspicious one. "Him, I get it, but aren't you supposed to be the thinky planny one?" she gestured at the colorful array spread before them. "Surely with *this much stuff* to keep track of, your turns, *at least*, should be taking longer."

"Well, dearest," Hordak said, smile widening into a wicked grin as he struggled to keep the laughter out of his voice. "I think you'll find that it's not hard for me to plan my next move when each of *your* turns take twenty minutes."

"[He's right.]" Imp said in Busy's voice.

Entrapta scowled at them both.

"Yeah well," she muttered, poking at the pieces with a tendril of hair. "I wouldn't take so long if you weren't so good at these kinds

of games."

Raising an eyebrow at her, Hordak reached out and picked up his tea. "Weren't you the one who suggested we play this?"

"*Hush you.*"

Chuckling softly, he sipped at his still slightly too warm drink and returned it to the side table next to him. Eyes roving across the adjusted board state, he considered his next move as he crossed his ankles and absently adjusted the crocheted blanket across his lap.

He'd just about decided on a course of action, plus potential alternatives, by the time the door to his left opened and Baker stepped inside the library.

"Sorry," she said. "I know you guys are in the middle of a game but there's someone here to see you and it feels like the kind of thing you wouldn't want to wait."

"Oh?" Entrapta looked up, perhaps a little too eagerly.

"They're just in the hallway, if it's alright to bring them in."

"Of course!" she replied, hands clapping together lightly. "We're not doing anything *that* important."

Hordak snorted, earning a sharp look from his partner and accompanying snickers from Imp, and nodded to Baker. She opened the door and, accompanied by Busy and Soda, "Mistress Blood Slicer" entered the room.

He raised an eyebrow at the young girl as she stood there, fidgeting with the edges of her shirt, and a glance at Entrapta confirmed that, yes, she was rather surprised to see her as well. After the first week had passed without any trace of them, then another, and the only one who'd shown up at the castle had been an elf in need of a bit of advice, they'd effectively given up on determining the fate of the kobold girl and her canid friend.

It was now bordering into four weeks since the unfortunate incident at Maurice's and the time had clearly not been good to the poor girl. There were new holes in her leggings and the clumsy repairs to the tears in her skirt suggested the additions weren't meant to be fashionable. She was still covered in far too many bits of cheap jewelry, but they seemed to fit looser than before on her skinny frame and there was a dullness to her scales that had nothing to do with dirt or the strong scent of wood smoke that clung to her and made his eyes itch.

"Well?" Baker said to the girl, the gentleness of her tone betraying her stern look and crossed arms. "Go on."

The kobold looked from Baker to the floor and nodded, swallowing several times. She reached a hand into the pocket of her vest and pulled out a grubby piece of folded notebook paper. Her hands shook and trembled as she unfolded the paper and it fluttered and crinkled in her claws while she took a deep breath and cleared her throat.

"D-dear miss Queen Entrapta a-and mister Lord Hordak," she squeaked out, eliciting a tiny gasp and "aww" from Entrapta. Hordak glanced at his partner and was not surprised to see her hand up to her mouth or the open expression of delight on her face.

"And miss Lord Hordak's Friend too," she continued, turning slightly and dipping her head towards Baker. "I-I'm sorry f-for what my friend and I did the other day, er, week. Uh, I mean, *weeks*...and, um, we shouldn't have done those things and I'm sorry we caused you and the nice baker people trouble. It was a stupid thing to do a-and even though he's not here, Ben's sorry for the things he said too."

Ben? Hordak looked to Entrapta who seemed confused as well until it clicked a moment later for the both of them; so *that* was "Lord Shadow Runner"'s real name.

"I- I- I hope you can forgive him," the girl continued. "He doesn't mean to be mean like that, he's just been through some bad stuff a-and it's like you said, mister Hordak, sir, when he gets scared he protects himself by getting angry."

Finished, the kobold girl abruptly dropped her arms to her side and stared at the floor, looking like she was about to cry. Behind her, Soda and Busy where both clinging to one another with absurd smiles on their faces and even Baker was struggling to maintain her severe expression. While Imp merely shrugged back at him and appeared to be generally neutral, Entrapta was practically vibrating in her seat, her hands balled up into fists and shaking excitedly next to her face, and her lower lip caught tightly between her teeth as she tried to stifle the high pitched keening sound she was making.

Hordak looked towards the ceiling for a moment, hoping he appeared contemplative to the kobold girl peeking up at him, as he took a deep breath and tried to corral his own emotions into something akin to neutral and dignified.

"What is your name?" he finally asked.

"A-Ashley. Sir."

"And how old are you?"

Ashley shuffled in place for a moment, biting her lip and flushing.

"...sixteen," she eventually mumbled.

Hordak nodded. "Thank you Ashley. I've spent very nearly that same amount of my life apologizing to others and I know full well how difficult and alarmingly vulnerable it can be."

Ashley's mouth dropped open and she stared at him.

"Oooooh I'm so proud of you!" Entrapta said, bouncing to her feet and half running up to the startled girl. "Can I hug you?"

“Uuh..?” Ashley looked nervously between Entrapta and Hordak.

“I believe,” he said, picking up his tea cup once more. “You will discover that Entrapta is an *expert* at hugs.”

“O-okay,” she rasped.

Half a heartbeat later she was swept up into Entrapta’s embrace. She stood there, stiff and awkward at first, but as Entrapta’s hair carefully wrapped around them, the smaller girl began to relax and lean into her. When Entrapta began gushing about how brave Ashley was, her eyes drifted closed and Hordak couldn’t help but share the girl’s contented smile.

There was still plenty of work to be done, true, but the first step had been taken and that was often the hardest one.

Chapter End Notes

> Special thanks to cruelfeline for her suggestions on board games Hordak would enjoy. ;D
>
> Also, slightly unrelated, maireadralph is putting together a community Entrapdak zine and everyone who's interested is invited to participate! Both written and visual contributions are welcome and there are no limits on skill levels and no applications; further details can be found here! If you're interested (I know I'm writing something) you've got until July 1st, 2021 to make a submission.

"Donut Wolf"

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Ben slipped into another sneezing fit, eyes watering and movements jerky, and stepped on a bad patch of leaves. Slippery from the morning's rain, they pulled out from under him and he slid hazardously across the dirt road, arms swinging wildly as he tried to regain his balance. His hand caught one of the cracked and weather beaten fence posts at the last second and he finally came to a stop, body contorted awkwardly and breathing hard.

The wind rustled the tall stalks of grass beside him and he sneezed again.

He let out a frustrated yell.

Stupid allergies! Stupid farm fields! Stupid mud, stupid leaves! Stupid orchard with its rotting fruit, stupid breeze smelling like horse shit! Stupid puddles making his pants legs wet and heavy, stupid growling stomach, stupid hypocritical Brightmooners being all suspicious of him and wrinkling their noses before he'd even said a stupid word or done anything! Stupid Hordak with his stupid clone face and his stupid "reasonable advice" and stupid Blood Slicer for defending the idiot.

No- not Blood Slicer- she wasn't *cool* enough for *that* name anymore, not after she ditched him like that.

Stupid, dumb, nerdy *Ashley* with her twiggy little legs that were ugly and not cute and her toothy grin that was dorky and not sweet and her nubby little horns that absolutely didn't look good in the rings she put on them and her stumpy hands that weren't good at getting the brambles out of his fur and didn't feel nice *at all.*

Stupid him for letting her naive ignorance and people pleasing attitude and hesitant optimism get under his defenses. He should've known better- other people were bad news; you don't make friends, just allies you can use and get rid of before they do it to you.

He growled at himself and readjusted the straps of his backpack before picking his way around the worst of the mud puddles and crabapples that had dropped past the fence line.

Man, he hated Etheria. The whole stupid place needed a facelift, *hard*.

Hordak might have given up all his manly pride for some stupid, pampered *princess* and Ashley might be too much of a coward to heed the call for action, but he knew one person who'd understand exactly what he meant, who wouldn't back down. *She'd* know better than *anybody* how badly Etheria needed new management and how to put those stuck up elitist royalists in their place; the only reason she hadn't done it yet was because nobody was supporting her! But that was fine- while the She-ra kept her under house arrest, he'd help her from the shadows.

He'd be her Shadow Runner.

Ben smirked to himself.

Heh. That was *so* cool.

His ear flicked and he looked to his left at the sound of someone whistling. Out in the field of purple grass, among the grazing horses, was a human girl with blonde hair. He relaxed a little when he realized she wasn't looking at him and was instead waving at a white horse with- were those wings? And a horn?

Man, even the countryside Brightmooners were weird.

The girl's head turned in his direction and he immediately looked away and continued walking. *Nothing to see here, I'm not trespassing, it's a public road- I checked- and I'm not doing*

anything wrong so leave me alone. You do your thing and I'll do mine so please just leave me alone, go away and leave me alone, fuck off and leave me alone-

He willed the words at her over and over as he hunched his shoulders and dug his hands in his pockets to grip his knife, but obviously she didn't pick up on any of it because it wasn't long before she and her weird horse had trotted up to the fence and were following him along side it.

"Hey there!" the blonde called out, all moonshine and rainbows.

Great.

"You lost?"

"No," he deadpanned back. He glanced from the pockmarked road to her, trying to gauge how much of a threat this annoyingly happy girl was. She looked like your average farmer, bulky and wearing a red plaid button down shirt and overalls; hell, she even had the damn farmer boots and straw hat.

What a generic nobody.

"Mind if I ask where you're heading?" At least her tone was still upbeat and she hadn't decided to bust out a pitchfork or whatever yet.

"Yeah, I mind."

"Oh. Well, it's just that there's really not much of anything out here for *miles* and I'd hate for you to go so far only to find out what you're looking for isn't there."

Yeah, yeah, I know, "get out of here you mangy mutt, you're not welcome here."

"I'm going to visit someone, alright?" Ben finally growled.

"Oh? Who's that?"

She sounded excited, but he could practically hear the *"you're lying, you just want to steal my horses, don't you"* between her words. People never said what they really meant and it was the plain Jane types like this you had to watch out for the most.

"If you *have* to know," he sneered up at her, puffing out his chest. "I'm going to visit Commander Catra."

"Ooooh," the girl said, mouth wide, head tilting back a little. "Yeeeah, *Commander* Catra, riiiight."

Did she just share a glance with her *horse?*

Man, and to think people call *him* crazy.

"Gotcha," the girl continued with a solemn nod and a chin stroke. "Well, you're definitely going the right way then." She pointed down the road. "She lives just up ahead. Take a left at the fork, you can't miss it."

"Thanks, I guess," he mumbled.

Not that I asked.

They went another good 50 feet down the road together before he scowled at her.

"You need somethin' else lady?" he growled.

"Oh, well, y'know," she shrugged, unfazed. "I was just thinking, you're probably pretty tired if you came all the way from town and I could give you a ride the rest of the way there, if you want."

Yeah, right, more like a ride into some ditch where no one will find me.

"No thanks."

She glanced at her horse again and this time he could have sworn the horse shrugged back at her.

“Alright, suit yourself.”

He watched her go and it wasn’t until she was far enough away that he could barely make her out among the horses that he let himself relax.

Stupid farm girl.

Just wait until him and Commander Catra set that whole stupid field on fire.

When he came to the fork he almost wanted to turn right, just to spite the goody-two-shoes blondie, but her directions matched the ones he had, so he didn’t really have much choice.

He hadn’t really been sure what to expect when he’d heard Commander Catra was living out in the Brightmoon countryside, but he’d ultimately assumed that was some kind of code for her being considered too dangerous to live near people or her being forced into some forsaken prison of some kind. It was the kind of thing the Princess Alliance did with people they didn't like now that they couldn't send people to Beast Island anymore.

He definitely hadn’t expected a white picket fence or chickens or a quaint farm house with a porch and a tree with a tire swing. He’d half assumed the person he could distantly make out putting laundry up on a clothes line was a servant or guard or *something*, but as he got closer, a sinking feeling formed in his stomach when he recognized the distinct tail and ears of a magicat.

She wasn’t dressed like a soldier.

She was heavier than in the pictures too. And shorter than he’d imagined.

There was a little kid playing in the dirt too.

It got even worse when the woman caught sight of him with familiar mismatched eyes and snorted out a low “oh, brother.”

He most certainly hadn’t expected his hero to laugh at him when he introduced himself or to roll her eyes when he knelt in front of her to pledge himself to her cause. He hadn’t foreseen her getting mad at him when he started telling her what a disappointing, whiny little pissant Hordak was either.

But of all the things Ben hadn’t expected, it was to wake up flat on his back several minutes later with the weirdo farm girl leaning over him, wrapped in glowing light, and telling him not to move just yet because she was still healing his concussion.

Chapter End Notes

> Ben, sweet baby edgelord, *please,* you've got to learn the meaning of "talk shit, get hit" my dude. -___-"

"The Bridge"

Chapter Notes

> A little reminder that maireadralph/Buzzthebatgirl's community Entrapdak zine project is ongoing and everyone is invited! Both written and visual contributions are welcome and there are no limits on skill level and no applications for approval; further details can be found here! If you're interested you've got until July 1st, 2021 to make a submission.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Okay, you guys wait here, I'll be right back!" Entrapta chimed out brightly.

Hordak nodded as she opened the door to the pastry shop and stepped inside. He glanced from the nervous kobold next to him to the fountain behind him and sat down on its edge to wait, idly spinning and twisting his cane. He hadn't really needed it today, per se, but he'd been carrying it around a lot more lately regardless because, he had to admit, Entrapta had been right once more: it *was* very stylish and it *did* match his favorite coat rather nicely and the items together created a pleasingly striking silhouette effect in the correct lighting. Hordak hummed thoughtfully; it seemed his propensity for vanity was growing as the years slid by.

He watched Ashley shift from foot to foot and chew at the ends of her claws. Occasionally she'd take a couple steps towards the fountain, almost as if to sit down with him, but then think better of it and turn towards the shop or retreat back to the spot she'd started in. Had it been earlier in the day, he'd have told her to sit so she wouldn't be in the way of general foot traffic, but with the daymoons quickly setting and most shops closing for the night, the few people who did pass by them were able to do so unmolested, albeit with plenty of curious glances.

Smart though Drylians were, they certainly loved their gossip too; Hordak could only begin to imagine how busy Maurice and Brioche would be tomorrow as word spread that one of the kids who'd broken their window had returned and people began inventing thinly veiled excuses to come in and talk.

When Ashley became caught in her fourth round of indecision and she looked up at the sky with a grimace and a whine while wringing her hands, his amused smiled softened into something far more sympathetic.

"It will be alright," he called out to her.

She jolted in place and whipped around to face him.

"Y-you're really sure this is the right thing to do?"

He raised a brow at her. "Do you have reason to suspect it is not?"

"Yes? No? I don't know." She rubbed at her face. "What if- oh, what if they hate me and never want to see me again? What if coming here only makes things worse?"

"Ashley," Hordak sighed, "it's a *window,* not a person's life."

"Yeah, but, it's already fixed so will apologizing really do anything to help?"

"I suppose that *does* depend on what a person considers helpful."

"'Cuz my dad only apologizes when he wants something or when it does something useful and then you *have* to forgive him, even if you don't really want to," Ashley replied, words speeding up and growing more and more frantic as she spoke. "-because that's what you're *supposed* to do because if you don't then you're being difficult and I hate that feeling and I don't want other people to feel like that but then people get even madder if you don't apologize!"

She remained oblivious to Hordak's narrowed eyes and low rumble of displeasure as she paced back and forth and gestured widely.

"Except then they *also* get upset if you do but not the right way or good enough or you don't act like they want and- and- it's all *awful* and- I just- ooooh, *I don't know!*"

Ashley finally dropped down next to him and groaned loudly into her hands.

Hordak looked up at the sky, took a long breath, and reminded himself that violence was neither useful in the moment nor an acceptable solution, *especially* against his partner's subjects.

Ah, but it *was* tempting sometimes, wasn't it? Maybe there was a grain of truth to what all these children were saying; after all, does a tamed beast ever *truly* stop being dangerous?

"...I see," he said softly, tone tight but even. He glanced through the bakery window, unsurprised to see Entrapta in animated conversation with Maurice; they definitely had a few minutes.

He turned in his seat towards Ashley and cleared his throat, prompting her to look at him through her fingers.

"I wish for you to take a deep breath."

She stared up at him in confusion for a moment but did as instructed and seemed to still a little.

"Excellent. As for your *father*," he tried to hold back the growl with limited success. "I do not think he has made himself into a very good role model."

Ashley curled her tail into her lap and took hold of it.

"...no," she whispered.

"With that in mind," he continued, "I hope you will reconsider the concept of an apology. While, yes, they can often be twisted and

used for such purposes, a good apology should never be a form of manipulation or social obligation. Do you honestly regret your actions?”

“...yes.”

“Very well then. In that case, all you can do is try.”

“What if they…”

“React negatively?”

Ashley nodded.

“Then that is their right and it is your job to accept that.” Hordak sighed. “People aren’t always ready to forgive, nor do they owe you such a thing, but it is still important to apologize, declare your intent to make amends in whatever way is appropriate to the situation, and give them the opportunity to confront you and express their own feelings.”

“...but I’m scared,” she whispered.

“A reasonable thing to feel; rejection is unpleasant in all its forms and there is always the potential for it in an apology.”

She squirmed a little in place and bowed her head once more. He held his hand out to her, palm up, loose and inviting.

“I assure you, it will be alright.”

She hesitantly set her hand in his; goodness, but it was small, even more so than Entrapta’s.

“How do you know?”

Hordak rubbed the back of her hand with his thumb and smiled wryly at her.

“Experience and the perspective of someone who is, for once, not in your shoes.”

"...what do you mean?"

"When done right, apologizing is a terribly exhausting and strenuous task, although many people do not wish to acknowledge that fact. Asking for help is arguably even worse. You have already endured much in gathering the necessary courage to come to us today to do both, so choosing to also come here and do what is right is no mean feat."

"You think so?"

"I do. Setting aside one's pride and trusting in the goodness and mercy of others is a terribly vulnerable experience."

"...I hate it."

"Indeed." Hordak let out an amused huff and smiled warmly at her. "Although it is easier said than done, please try to relax. Maurice and Brioche are understanding people; they will not shout or berate you. I cannot say how, exactly, they'll react, but I do know that, so long as you are genuine and honest with them, they will listen."

Ashley smiled tentatively up at him and opened her mouth, but before she could get the words out the bakery's doorbell jangled and they both looked over to see Entrapta there, several small pastries clutched in her hair and waving at them.

It was not, perhaps, the most graceful apology Hordak had ever heard, but he could not deny Ashley's sincerity and, really, he'd done worse in his time.

Her words had begun slow and halting as she'd trembled under Maurice's frown and she'd kept glancing at Brioche's impassive expression and crossed arms. Nevertheless, everyone let her speak freely, only ever interrupting to ask questions or prompt clarification, and, with his and Entrapta's small nods of encouragement, she gradually opened up.

Having said that, when she was finally done she still appeared, to his eye, to be on the verge of tears.

Maurice sighed and set his hands on his hips.

“Well, alright. No one was really hurt and that’s what matters. Things are just things; they can be replaced.” He glanced over at Brioche who did not look away from Ashley or acknowledge his partner. “Bri?”

The clone blinked slowly and tilted his head, brow finally creasing.

“Why did you wait?” Brioche asked softly.

Ashley’s eyes went wide. “W-what?”

“I saw you watching in the window. You already had the brick. You could have hit me very easily and had plenty of time to do so. Why didn’t you?”

Everyone’s stares shifted from him to Ashley.

“I-I-I...I didn’t…” she stammered and bowed her head, “...want to hurt anyone.”

“Then why do it at all?”

“I just wanted to break the window,” she murmured. “We knew it would probably make a couple people mad, but it was supposed to be like a practical joke- it’s not funny or cool anymore if somebody actually gets hurt.”

Brioche considered her for a long moment and nodded. He turned and left, slipping into the backroom without another word. Everyone watched him in confused silence and even Maurice seemed at a loss. However, before anyone could come to a consensus on what to do, Brioche returned, a small white cardboard box in hand.

He knelt on one knee in front of Ashley and looked long and hard into her eyes.

"I believe you," he finally said.

He held out the box to her and she took it in trembling hands. He nodded when she looked from him to the box and she opened it, letting out a little gasp. Hordak, Entrapta, and Maurice all craned their heads to see, eyebrows raising in surprise.

There was a beautiful golden brown pastry rose inside, its red tipped edges dusted in powdered sugar.

Ashley looked up at him with open mouthed shock.

Brioche smiled gently back at her. "We are more than the mistakes of our past. Grow."

This time when he got up to leave, he did not come back, and when Maurice turned away from where his partner had disappeared to, his face was flushed with pleasure.

"Well, I'll be damned," he chuckled. "I think that might be the most I've ever heard him say in front of a stranger in...ever. Normally it's a struggle to get him to say more'n maybe ten words in a day to anyone but me."

Ashley's dumbfounded expression shifted from the backroom door to Maurice and back again while, beside her, Entrapta was scrunched up in a silent squeal of delight.

Maurice shook his head and looked to Hordak, nodding towards Ashley.

"She staying with you guys up at the castle?"

"For the time being, yes," he replied. Entrapta nodded enthusiastically as well.

“Mm, alright.” Maurice paused a moment to think and then looked back to Ashley, ensuring he had her attention. “Tell you what- you come back in the morning. I need to chat with Bri first, but I might have somethin’ for you if you’d like to help.”

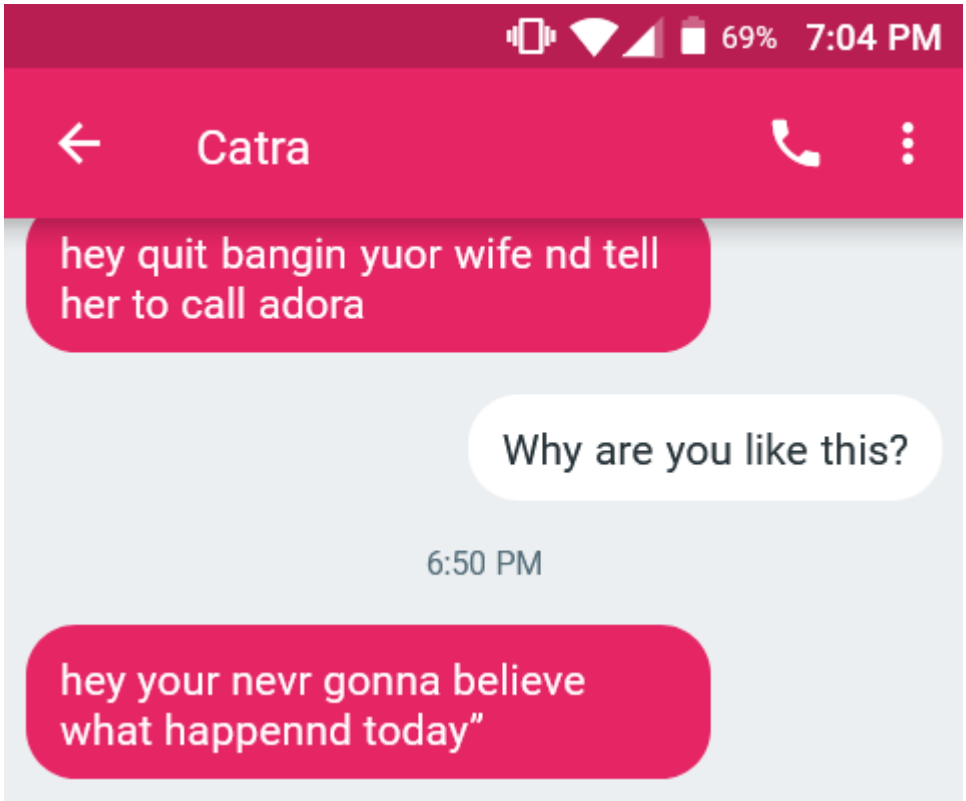
The kobold nodded.

“And,” he continued, “make sure you count your lucky stars tonight- not everyone’s as generous as the Queen or the Prince here.”

“Yes sir,” Ashley said faintly, looking from Entrapta to Hordak. “I will sir.”

Entrapta was practically vibrating where she stood by the time they finished their goodbyes with Maurice and she hardly missed the chance to jump and twirl several times once they were outside. Ashley, for her part, seemed stuck in a daze as she walked in little zigzags, too busy looking awestruck at her gift from Brioche to really pay attention to where she was going. Seeing this, Entrapta quickly returned to them and gently snaked a tendril of hair around the girl’s shoulders to guide her away from obstacles. Hordak shared a knowing smile with his partner.

As the three of them made their way back up to the castle, his communicator buzzed and he fished it out of his interior breast pocket.



Hordak raised a brow and smirked.

And what if I can?

psh- no way

Did a raggedy young man with grey fur appear at your door asking to join your revolution or somesuch?

ajkfhksfdlholy shit!!!!

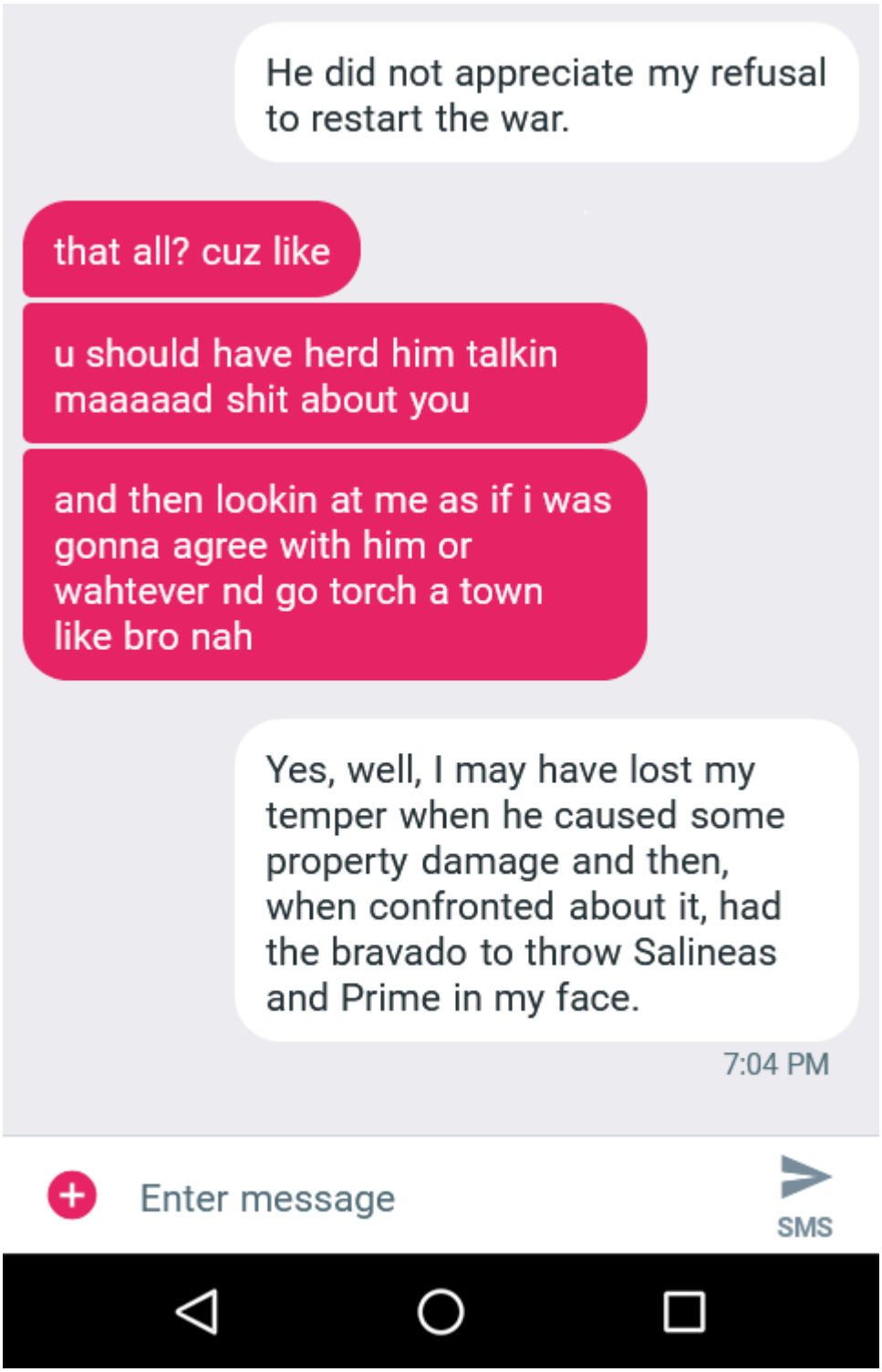
I hope Ben is well.

eh, adoras got him helping her and swiftwind while i make dinner hell be fine

but like

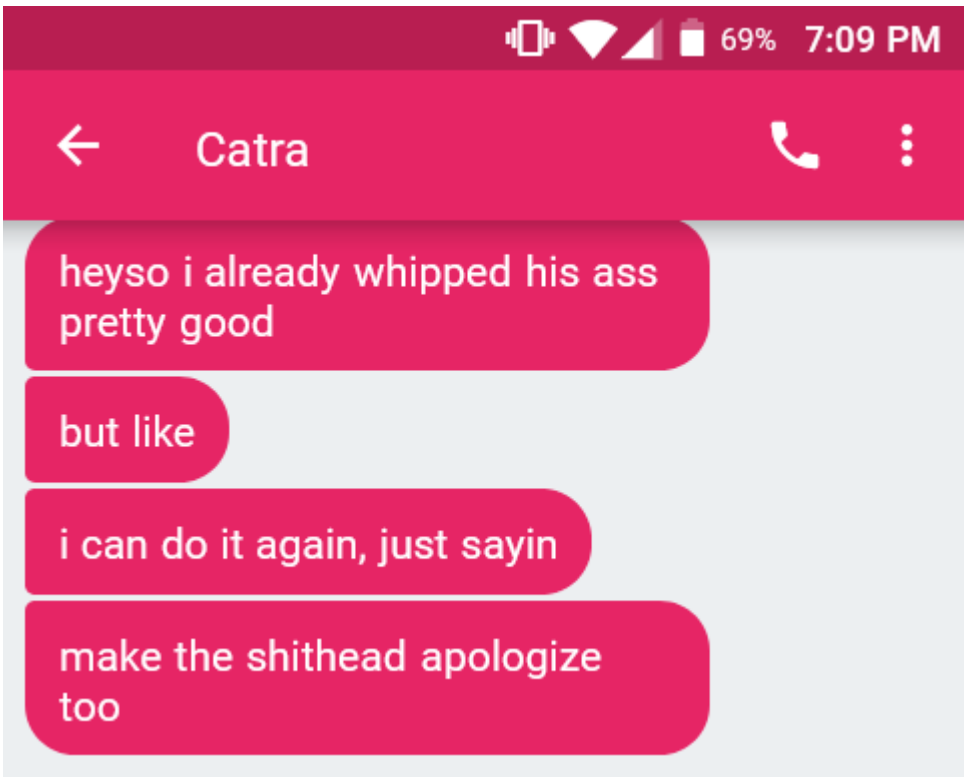
dude

what dd you even DO to that kid nyway!?



He stared down at the communicator for a long moment, growing a touch nervous as the seconds stretched by into a full minute without a reply. It was likely nothing, she had mentioned she was cooking after all, and yet...Catra was typically a rather rapid typist; it was unlike her to pause like thi- oh, yes, there- the little

icon indicating she was composing her reply- except that was also lingering longer than usual...



Ah.

He suddenly had the mental image of her screaming obscenities in front of her stove.

There is no need.

hrodak cmon man

Yes.

I know.

I am not dodging an apology out of a misplaced sense of self-loathing.

do u tho?

you sure cause ypu still suck at letting beople say sorry to you

Yes, I am sure.

I think,

way too much

(Hah hah)

I think I would rather just know that he's been pointed in a better direction.

well adora seems to like him already nd yuo kno how much she likes adoptin gthese kids

A fact which brings Entrapta and I great comfort at night, yes.

...It would also be nice to know that he's being educated not to make reductive generalizations about my kindred.

on it.

got any hot tips for me then? since u seem to kno the kid already?

Well, his companion, Ashley, is here with us, if he asks. She speaks of him quite highly and claims that, beyond the prickly exterior, he is very kind.

She said he has experienced numerous traumatic events, although she has been vague on the details and we have not pressed.

yeh big surprise there

ashley?

Entrapta shot him a questioning look over her shoulder as he turned his communicator in their direction to snap a photo. He mouthed back “a moment” to her and she shrugged.



aw fuck shes cute are those spiders on her leggings???

Yes.

akjskalkf

yeah ok whyd you get the adorable one and i got the dumbass

Because the ones looking for a fight and needing to blow off steam almost always do better with you?

yeah prob for the best

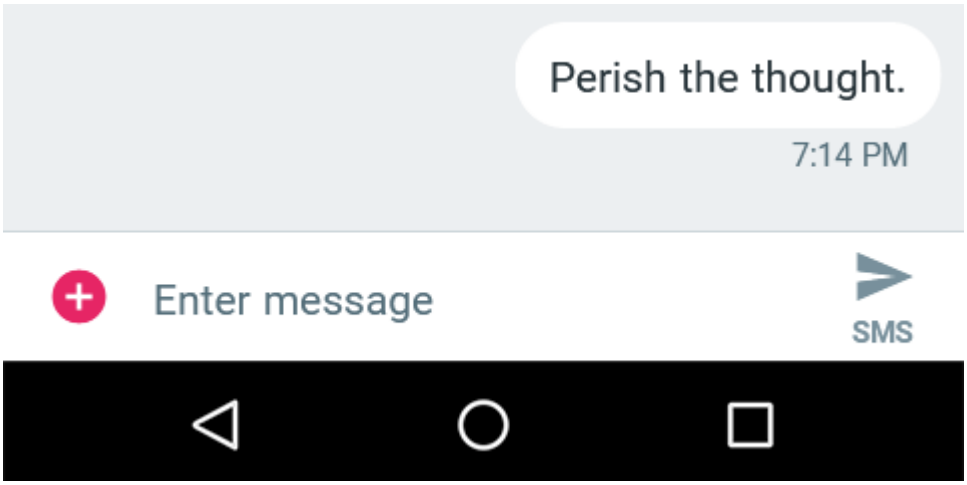
theyd break yur frail ass too easy

cant have that

wouldnt want entrapta unleshing a horde of murderbots on the planet

really ruin my weekend plans yknow?

Hordak snorted and grinned.



Chapter End Notes

crosses fingers Here's hoping that formatting for the text conversation worked out. I'd originally just written it out in a traditional dialogue style but then went digging on a whim to see if text message generators were a thing and discovered they were, indeed (shock and awe, it's not the 90s anymore: resources *exist* now).

By this point I think it may be beginning to be obvious to anyone that's familiar with it that the story and chapter titles are all references to songs from the soundtrack for the game *Night in the Woods*, particularly the songs Die Anywhere Else and "Weird Autumn" which I felt fits both how Hordak once went through life and what Ben and Ashley are feeling now. That might seem like a bit of a strange comparison (especially since the song titles don't really match up with the chapter content, *sigh*) but I think anyone who's familiar with the game might be able to suss out the vibe I'm aiming for.

"Gregg's Woods"

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Here we are!" Busy said, spinning in place and throwing a hand out towards the bakery with an animated flourish. "My sister lives just down the road, so I'll swing by and check in to make sure you're doing alright when we're done, okay?"

Ashley nodded, half convinced the woman's smile and wink had actually sparkled with real stars for a moment.

"Great! See ya!"

"U-um!"

Busy paused mid step and half turned back towards her. "Hm?"

"I- uh...thanks. Miss Busy."

She giggled back and flapped a hand. "No problem!"

Ashley watched her go and turned to the glass and wood door next to her.

She took a few deep breaths.

Mister Maurice had been very patient with her yesterday just like Lord Hordak had said, so everything would be okay. They wouldn't have invited her back if she wasn't wanted, she was just being paranoid. Plus, Mister Brioche had given her that really nice gift!

Ashley sighed wistfully, wishing she was back in her room again with it in her lap and not here in front of this door.

She'd stared at the box nearly the whole night. It had so completely awed and amazed that something so lovely could possibly have been given to someone like *her*; the idea of eating it

seemed almost unbearable- it was so beautiful, how could she possibly ruin it like that?- but letting it go stale or rot would have been even worse. She'd thought about it almost constantly the whole night, almost afraid to let the box out of her sight lest it poof away into thin air and turn out to be some kind of desperate hallucination. But it had still been there on the nightstand of her new bedroom when she'd come back from dinner and no one touched it while she'd taken her bath or changed into the new pajamas Mister Soda had found for her.

It'd been so unexpectedly easy to fall asleep; she'd felt so warm and the bed was so soft and everything had been clean and comfortable and she was full and content and *safe* and she wasn't really all that sure she could have stayed awake even if she'd tried. Yet, when she finally did wake up, her heart had raced and she'd been disoriented and panicked; everything was so different and it all felt like some kind of awful trap waiting to be sprung or a cruel lie at her expense, like some malevolent force had been waiting for her to let down her guard so they could gobble her up like in a fairy tale.

It had been so hard to breathe and it was difficult to tell if she was even awake or stuck in one of her nightmares, but then she'd caught sight of the little white cardboard box on the nightstand, exactly the same as she'd left it, and somehow she hadn't felt so scared anymore because there it was: proof that genuine kindness existed in the world, the sort that didn't predicate on a person's usefulness or feeling of begrudging obligation or short lived pity.

She'd curled back into her blankets then and turned on her side to stare at the box, watching the moonlight coming through her window slowly move across it with something akin to reverence.

Eventually the temptation became too much for her and she'd darted a hand out from under her covers to snatch the box into the protective confines of her cotton cocoon. There, safe once more, she'd hesitantly lifted the cardboard lid and sighed in relief: it was still there, it was real, and it was just as beautiful as she'd remembered.

If she could have preserved it in some way, freeze it in time or turn it to crystal or encase it in glass, she would have. No one had ever really given her something before that was completely and totally hers; everything she'd ever owned had always been ratty hand-me-downs or something she'd been forced to share. She'd instinctively clung onto it with all the jealousy of a deprived child and wondered how long it would take before the Queen or Lord Hordak or one of the staff asked her for it, positively dreading the idea of having to share even this with them and berating herself for being so selfish to people who had done- who were *doing*- so much for her. What right would she have to deny them? Obviously no more than she'd had with her father or her exhausted older brothers or her watery eyed little brothers who didn't yet understand how little they all had.

It was immeasurably silly to be so attached and worked up by something as simple as a bit of baked dough, she knew, but she just couldn't help it. New things, beautiful things, things that were special and nice just weren't something she was used to and it made it hard to believe the rose staring back up at her in the dimness of her blanket pile was real. That it was *hers*. That she could do whatever she wanted with it and no one would say a *word*.

The only way to really appreciate the gift was to eat it before it went bad, she knew, but if she rationed it carefully maybe she could savor it. So, she counted. And then she double counted. And then she delicately peeled exactly two petals away from the flower and promised to herself to do the same thing every night for the next week until it was gone.

It had been the most wonderful thing she could ever remember tasting. It was flaky and crunchy and sweet and decadent and absolutely not something she deserved and yet all she could do in the moment was sniffle and rub away the water at the corners of her eyes and thank the spirits of the mountain for the generosity of others.

Ashley let out a shuddery breath and rubbed her clammy hands against the fabric of her vest. She tried not to think about the vest's frayed ends and the rude badges she'd put on it she'd forgotten to remove, or the amateurishly mended tears in her repurposed school uniform skirt, or how out of place she must look in this nice square around all these pretty shops and cozy cottages. She could pretend to be tough all she wanted but it would never change the fact that someone like her didn't belong here. No matter how much the Queen's staff had helped her clean up, as far as she was concerned she'd always be a grubby little goblin from a dead-end corner of a tiny town tucked so far away in some mountain caves most people didn't even know they existed.

Ashley closed her eyes and bounced a little on her toes, trying to breathe calmly the way Lord Hordak had instructed her.

Mister Maurice and Mister Brioche were waiting for her. Miss Busy would be back in a few hours too. Everyone would be disappointed in her if she ran away now and her gift was still back at the castle, waiting for her to come back and have two more precious bites.

She'd already been standing out here for so long, it would be weird if she stayed any longer.

She had to stop thinking and just do it.

Wasn't that what Ben was always telling her? That she's her own worst enemy and how she has a bad habit of talking herself out of things? They might have said some mean things to each other the last time they'd talked but that didn't change the fact that he was right and even if she didn't really know where he was, she knew he'd be cheering her on if he was here now.

Oooooh, she wished he was here. It was so much easier to be brave with him around.

With a little keening sound in the back of her throat and a few nervous stamps of her feet in place, Ashley finally reached out for the bakery's door handle and stepped inside.

She hesitated just past the doorway when she didn't immediately spot either of the bakery's owners. She could hear a little bit of strained grunting from behind the counter and it wasn't long before the sound of the door bell prompted a muffled "Just a minute!"

Maurice appeared a few moments later through the backroom door, mopping sweat off his flushed face with a handkerchief.

"Oh!" he panted. "Good timing. Well come on then."

He lifted up a section of the register counter and stepped back a little, gesturing for her to follow. She scurried forward, trying her best to stay out of the way as he returned the counter section to its place.

"You're helping Bri today," he said, pointing through the doorway. "Off you go, straight down into the kitchen."

"Y-yes sir!" she squeaked.

Staring around herself wide-eye and terrified of potentially taking a wrong turn or getting lost, she passed the open doorways of what seemed like a tiny office and a big storeroom. She could feel Maurice behind her but glanced back when she heard his footsteps stop; he was standing in the storeroom door, watching her.

"You're alright- it's just a bit farther," he called after her. "Oh! And make sure you wash your hands first- can't be handling food without clean hands."

She nodded emphatically. "Yes sir!"

Maurice was right, of course, and the hallway quickly ended in what was obviously the kitchen. It didn't take any effort to spot

Brioche among the rolling baking racks and tables and equipment- he was so *big*. Well, to be fair, at barely more than four feet tall, *everyone* was big compared to her, but it wasn't like she wasn't familiar with or even used to seeing clone brothers around- because she was!- and yet, there was just *something* about the space that made it feel like he was towering over her more than usual, even from the other side of the room.

She twisted the end of her tail between her hands as she watched him load several trays from the rack next to him into the oven and tried to suppress a squeak of fear when the oven door clattered shut and his honey gold eyes landed on her.

Brioche smiled at her and she thought he might have even done that same style of breathy huff-laugh through his nose that Lord Hordak does too. He pointed at a spot to her left and she let out a little "oh!" of realization at the sight of the sink.

She tried not to think too hard about what Brioche might be doing behind her as she turned on the water and she startled when he silently appeared next to her a moment later.

"For your jewelry," he said softly, setting a small clay bowl down next to the sink.

"Oh! Right!"

Ashley quickly removed the variety of plastic, yarn, and tarnished metal adorning her fingers and wrists, arranging the colorful mess as best she could into the little bowl. She reached for the necklaces hanging low across her chest and looked up at him questioningly.

"Um…?"

Brioche reached under his collar in response, pulling out a silver chain with a ring on it for her to see before tucking it back under his shirt. She nodded and followed his example.

Seemingly pleased, he disappeared for a moment while she scrubbed at the faded pen ink on her hands and forearms, and reappeared as she was drying off. He held out a work apron similar to his own and she slipped the overly large garment over her head.

Brioche touched a hand to his mouth to hide his grin at the way the apron hung low enough on her to nearly touch the floor and Ashley smiled self-consciously back, giggling a little herself as well. He reached out and delicately began adjusting the neck strap until the whole thing fit a bit more reasonably on her, finishing by stooping down to help her tie it in the back.

He tipped his head over his shoulder in a silent "follow me" and led her across the room to a work counter running along the wall. Spread across it was a variety of pre-prepped ingredients, including a bowl of apple slices soaking in water.

Except...oh.

That was why everything had felt so big to her: the counter came all the way up to her chest.

She was used to ones that only went to a little above her waist but this counter would have her almost brushing the undersides of her arms against the surface as she worked. How could she possibly help Brioche like that?

Crestfallen, she looked from the counter to the clone beside her, expecting annoyance but instead discovering...mirth? He was hiding an even wider grin- she was pretty sure she could even see his golden teeth through his fingers!- and he held up a finger as if to say "one moment please" before walking away. When he returned, he was carrying a step stool and set it on the floor for her to stand on.

"Oh, uh, heh...thanks," she whispered.

Problem solved, Brioche stepped up to the counter and indicated for her to watch him as he deftly assembled the apple slices

across a strip of dough and rolled them them together. Ashley gasped in delight when she realized he'd created a small version of the pastry rose he'd given her the day before and he appeared pleased by her recognition.

He assembled another for her, going through the steps much more slowly for her to see, before pulling the ingredients into her reach and indicating she try alongside him the third time. It wasn't a particularly difficult thing to do- drizzle some honey on the dough, line the apple slices along the top half of the strip, sprinkle a little cinnamon on top, fold the dough over, and roll it all together- but her hands were clumsy and slow and the dough kept tearing which made her flower look way more messy and uneven than Brioche's did.

She looked from her ugly rose to Brioche, cringing and ready for him to finally begin shouting about how useless she was and kick her out before she could ruin more of their wonderful store.

"Good," Brioche said with an encouraging nod. "Try again."

Ashley gaped up at him in complete amazement for several long heartbeats. Her eyes began watering and she quickly turned away in embarrassed horror.

"I-I'm sorry!" she croaked, scrubbing at her face with the back of her arm. Brioche was being so nice to her, *again*, and here she getting weepy like a total idiot and wasting his time!

Except...Brioche didn't shout at her or get angry or even sigh aggressively in irritation like she expected.

Instead he reached out and tenderly drew her close for a loose hug. He was wonderfully large and solid and when she relaxed into the hug and pressed her face into his soft chest, his arms tightened around her. He smelled like cut fruit and flour and when she couldn't hold back her sob any longer, rather than getting mad at her, he gently rubbed her back and whispered "It's okay now."

Chapter End Notes

This was the originally planned ending when I first extended the one shot idea out into a fuller story, but thanks to so many people's very kind and passionate comments and questions about Ashley and Ben, there is now an additional ~epilogue~ in the works. I come from a very OC-hostile historical fandom experience, so I never intended any of the OCs to get as much screentime or emphasis as they did, let alone expect people to want to see what becomes of them. I appreciate it, you guys are the best!!

Also, the treat Brioche is teaching Ashley to make is called an apple rose. I felt like he'd pick something easy to learn that still looks impressive so that Ashley would have something she could feel proud of after her first day, just like Maurice did for him years and years before. <3

"Cycles II"

Chapter Notes

> Surprise! Maireadralph made some fanart of Ashley and Ben! Go check it out and give her some love!
>
> Also! Speaking of maireadralph/Buzzthebatgirl, a final reminder that her community Entrapdak zine project is going to be wrapping up soon (July 1st, 2021)! Submissions of *all kinds* are welcome with no minimum skill levels or applications; further details are here. Mine's about 3/4ths of the way complete and, last we heard, the zine has over 20 submissions already, so it's definitely firing off and you'll definitely be among good company!

Entrapta let out a delighted whoop as the ship flew overhead and darted forward, cresting the last of the stairs leading up to the flightpad and flashing out of sight. Hordak squinted as the ship prepared to land and brought a hand up to shield his face from the gusts of wind and dirt being stirred up. While the First Ones ship was hardly the loudest spacecraft he'd encountered in his life, his ears still pulled back as he too reached the top of the climb and stepped into the open. He nodded politely to the crew of engineers moving busily about the tarmac and waited next to his practically vibrating partner.

He reached up to smooth his hair back into place once the ship finally came to a full stop and chuckled when Entrapta bolted forward the absolute *moment* the ship gangway began lowering. She made it before the gangway finished touching down and danced in place, fists clenched and shaking in front of her, until a familiar pink holographic orb appeared in front of her.

"Darla!" she cried out, immediately wrapping herself around the orb.

"Hello, Entrapta."

Entrapta immediately launched into a speedy conversation with the AI and Hordak could not help but smile fondly at them. Bright laughter drew his attention to the top of the gangway where Adora was watching as well.

"Hey, Entrapta," Adora called out as she began making her way towards Hordak. Entrapta twisted in place as she passed and waved back with drawn out "hi" and a toothy grin.

He stepped forward, meeting Adora halfway, and wrapped an arm around her shoulders to draw her in for a half-hug.

"It's good to see you!" Adora said, words muffled slightly into his shoulder.

"And you," he replied warmly. Adora gave his waist a little emphatic squeeze before stepping back and he looked back to the ship questioningly. "No Catra?"

She shook her head. "Nah. Finn came down with a little cold the other night and still had a bit of a fever this morning, so Catra elected to stay behind with them."

"Ah, I'm sorry to hear that. Is there anything we can do?"

"Eh, don't worry about it." Adora waved her hand. "It's pretty normal little kid stuff. What about you though?"

Hordak's head tilted. "Me?"

"Yeah, you. Entrapta mentioned you were pretty sick recently."

"Ah, that. It was of no consequence; merely a somewhat nasty flare that lingered longer than usual, no doubt exacerbated by the string of nasty weather we've been having recently."

"Yeah?"

"Indeed." He rolled his eyes. "I am convinced it would be more efficient to rename spring around here 'second winter' and be

done with the pretense that it will do *anything* but storm the majority of the time. As it stands, we are rather lucky it is not raining currently."

She cracked a smile but continued to eye him wearily. "Sure, but, I dunno, the way Entrapta was talking, it kind of sounded like it was a lot worse than that."

"Mm, yes, well, Entrapta tends to worry about me a hair more than is, perhaps, strictly necessary." Hordak let out an amused puff of air through his nose and tilted his head in concession. "Not that I have not given her reasonable cause in the past."

"Yeah, okay," Adora laughed. "But- sorry, you're probably sick of hearing this by now- but you're *sure* you're alright? Like, it's okay for you to be out and about and you don't still need to be at home taking it easy or something like that?"

Hordak smiled affectionately at her.

"Fifteen, twenty years ago? Certainly not. Such a thing would have been nerve wracking to contend with. But now? Now I have more people looking after me than I quite know what to do with."

Adora raised a brow smirked. "A whole castle's worth?"

"Precisely." He chuckled. "Although, if it is of any consolation to you as it was for Entrapta, I *did* arrange a visit with the doctor, just to be sure, and all is well."

"Good," she said with emphasis. Her smile brightened a moment later as she switched subjects. "So, you guys been working on anything exciting recentl-"

She was cut off as Entrapta bounded up and the two women immediately began their own round of hugs and pleasantries. Once finished, Entrapta turned to him and gestured back to the First Ones ship.

"Darla says hi, by the way."

“Ah, yes.” He looked up at the ship and called out. “Good morning, Darla.”

“Hello, Hordak.”

He nodded and looked back to Entrapta, holding out the crook of his arm for her to take. She did, an additional tendril of hair joining her hand to wrap up his bicep, and he gestured invitingly with his spare hand to Adora.

“Shall we then?”

“Uuuh...yeah, but...” Adora hesitated and looked between them and the ship with a bit of a frown. “Dang it. I’d kind of hoped he’d come out on his own. Sorry, would you guys gimme just a sec?”

“Of course!” Entrapta said.

The two of them shared a curious glance while Adora returned to the ship and followed her, drawing up short at the bottom of the gangway to peer through the open hatch. They could just barely hear Adora talking to someone beyond it.

“-ou coming? ...Well, no, you don’t have to come if you don’t want to… Of course you don’t- ...yeah, but, I mean, you came all this way and you *were* the one who suggested it… Sure, but don’t you think it’d be a good idea to at least try?”

Entrapta gasped beside him. “Oh. My. Goodness.” Her grip on his arm tightened a fraction and she looked up at him wide eyed. “Is that who I think it is?”

It was.

Ears pressed low, tail tight against his legs, head hung between his shoulders, and hands tucked into the pockets of his zipper hoodie, Ben tried his best to hide behind Adora as he followed behind her- a noble but futile endeavor for someone several inches taller than her and significantly broader. Much like Ashley, the general aesthetic of his appearance had not changed much

since they'd last encountered him, but the new button down flannel shirt suited him and his cargo pants had been mended so they no longer dragged along the ground. Likewise, with the way his fur shined in the daylight, it was clear he'd taken well to a steady diet and "the healing effects of good country air," as Adora was so fond of putting it.

Hordak suppressed the urge to laugh when he caught sight of the jumbled mess of colored wool that wrapped around the base of the canid's ears and tumbled down the back of his head; apparently Ben had also been victim to another one of Catra's attempts at "knitting" as well. He suspected it was *supposed* to be a variety of slouch beanie cap, but it seemed that every time Catra had attempted to change colors (which was often), the rows grew more and more crooked and several knots and gaps were apparent where something had gone wrong and she'd lacked the patience to undo her work to fix it.

Entrapta shared a knowing glance with him, also biting down a grin; they had received similar gifts from Catra last Solstice- her a pair of gloves and him a pair of socks, both in similar states. Hordak would have thought it impressive that Ben would continue to wear his hat outside of Catra's sight line except that, if the way Ashley clung to even the most mundane gifts was anything to go by, he had the feeling the young man genuinely liked it.

Ben continued to stand behind Adora long after they'd come to a stop, looking anywhere but at them. There was an extended pause as Adora looked from him to them and back, eventually broken by Entrapta.

"Welcome to Dryl, Lord Shadow Runner."

Ben startled at that and grimaced at the ground.

"It's...Ben. Actually," he mumbled. "My name is Ben."

"Okay then, it's nice to meet you Ben!" Entrapta replied, not missing a beat.

Another awkward pause, broken by Adora elbowing Ben and shooting him a meaningful glance. He nodded a fraction and stepped forward, glancing up at Hordak for a brief moment before looking down at the ground once more.

"I'm sorry. For the stuff I said." Ben ground his teeth, eyes darting up at him several times. "I went way over the line and it was bullshit of me to do any of that."

"Thank you. I am relieved to see you doing well."

Ben's head shot up, his mouth hanging open, and Hordak smiled broadly at him. While the canid was still slinking about with all the regrettably familiar signs of habitual paranoia, it was difficult to imagine this young man was the same person he'd nearly come to blows with last autumn. There was hardly any need for him to draw things out the way they had with Ashley; Adora and Catra had done their work well and he couldn't have been happier.

"Actually, now that I'm thinking of it…" Hordak said, fishing his communicator out of his interior breast pocket to check the time. "Yes. It will be lunchtime soon and we *will* be passing through town on our way back to the castle anyway…"

Entrapta gasped beside him, bouncing on her heels as she caught on. "Ooooooohhhh! Oh oh oh yes! Yes, we definitely should!"

Brioche twisted the plastic bag closed and affixed the clip just as the timer went off.

"Oh, darn it," Ashley muttered. She looked up from the assortment of boxes, filling bags, and cookies in front of her to the beeping oven with a grimace.

"I've got it," he called out to her. He set the bag of rolls down with the others on the roller rack and strode over to the oven, clicking the timer off and grabbing a pair of gloves. He pulled two trays of colorful confections out and set them on the cooling rack next to Ashley's work station.

“Thanks,” she smiled up at him, “I’m pretty sure that’s the last of them.”

Brioche nodded and returned the gloves to their hook. He did one final check to ensure they hadn’t missed anything and switched the oven off.

Ah, how had he and Mory gone so long without taking on an apprentice? He was still so unused to how much more quickly the day’s work went by with an extra pair of hands; aside from a bit of prep work for tomorrow and some cleaning, they were already very nearly done for the day and with so much of it left over! Brioche smiled and stretched as he returned to his rolls. Maybe he’d walk to the park and do a bit of sketching while Mory minded the shop. Perhaps the lookout; the valley below always looked especially nice after a few days of consecutive rain and the crocuses ought to be blooming soon, if they weren't already.

He bagged the last of the rolls and added them to the rack. He grabbed a few of their other finished items and filled the roller before pushing it towards the doorway.

“You heading up front?”

He nodded.

“Mmkay, I’m nearly done with these, so I’ll be up soon too.”

Brioche nodded once more and made his way down the hall, pausing briefly as he passed Maurice at the counter to rub between his shoulders. He murmured appreciatively but did not look up from the order forms he was filling out.

A few minutes passed in comfortable silence, broken only by the soft crinkling of plastic and Maurice’s quiet mumbling as he flipped through the forms. Brioche was nearly halfway through offloading his rolls when the doorbell jangled and someone hesitantly stepped inside. He looked up, first seeing the Queen waving at them vigorously through the window in front of him, then the familiar grey furred canid standing at the door. Brioche returned

the Queen's wave with a tiny one of his own and she shot him a thumbs up before disappearing, an action which- from the panicked look he sent behind himself- seemed to distress the young man significantly.

"Can I help you?" Maurice called from the counter.

"Is, um, Ashley here?"

"Oh, it's you."

Brioche did not miss the iciness in Maurice's tone and neither, it seemed, did the canid.

"Y-yes sir. I'm sorry for the trouble sir."

"Mmmm, well," Maurice set his pen down and gave him a suspicious look, "I can't say I was too happy about it-"

Suddenly there was a shrill gasp of delight and Maurice jumped in place as a crate was deposited next to him on the counter and a blur of olive green shot past him, latching onto the young man at the door.

"Ben! Oh my goodness, I'm so glad to see you!"

Brioche looked from the stunned canid to his slack jawed husband and covered his mouth to muffle his laugh; so much for Mory's plan on giving Ben a bit of "tough love" when he eventually showed back up. He tried a few times to draw their attention and continue his prepared lecture but Ashley's exuberance completely drowned it out until he had no choice but to give up with a sigh and shake of his head.

Brioche's chest shook with silent laughter as he listened to Ashley talk at Ben and finished putting the rolls away, her joy utterly infectious and leaving nearly no room for the stammering boy to reply. Despite his annoyance, even Maurice had a begrudging smile growing under his mustache.

“Oh, oh- come here and look at this!”

Ashley dragged Ben over to a display shelf festooned in ribbons, crepe paper, and folded paper stars. It clashed with the rest of the warm wood and gold trim design of the shop and yet it was a bright shock of color that was entirely and completely her.

“Tadaaa!”

“Uuhh…?”

“This is my spot! Oh- wait- just a sec!” Ashley dashed to the counter and grabbed the crate of boxes she’d left there. She quickly began refilling the shelf. “Look, see? Bri and Maurice let me have it and now I get to bake and put whatever I want on it!”

Ben looked wide eyed at the display. “Y-you *made* these?”

“Yup!”

He picked a box up, turning it back and forth to look at the cookies inside through the little plastic window in the front.

“What are they?”

“Macarons! Bri doesn’t like making them because he thinks they’re finicky and boring to do, so Maurice used to make them, but only when Her Majesty requested them. And he's right, they are kind of easy to mess up, but I really like making them anyway because you can give them all kinds of good colors and flavors, plus they’re really light and crunchy and melt in your mouth and-”

Ashley’s excited chattering faded away as Brioche returned to the back room, depositing his roller rack and taking the stairs to their living space above the shop. He prepared a bundle of sandwiches and a thermos of tea for two and returned to the shop front a few minutes later, unsurprised to find the duo exactly as he'd left them.

“-en saving up to rent this really cute cottage nearby, so you can come stay with me whenever you want, if you’d like!”

Brioche quietly chuckled again; this poor boy was completely outclassed, especially with Ashley in full "gush mode."

“Ash?” He lightly touched Ashley’s shoulder.

“Huh?”

“The weather has been nice today.” He held out the bundle and thermos to her and nodded towards the door.

“Oh!” she gasped. “But- we still need to-”

“I have it.”

“Thank you!” She took the items and gave him a tight hug, mumbling “you’re the best” so only he could hear. Pulling away, she shot him a wide grin and grabbed Ben’s hand, dragging him outside.

Brioche watched them go with a big smile of his own, unsurprised to see Mory shaking his head at him.

“You spoil her.”

“Maybe,” he said, stepping up to the counter and leaning over it to plant a kiss on the top of Maurice’s balding head. “But I’m hardly the only one.”

"Yeah, yeah. Love you too."

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!